

World War II in Europe

Barely two decades after World War I ended in 1918, war broke out across Europe once again in 1939. World War II was the deadliest conflict in human history. Around 70 million people lost their lives, and countries across the world suffered devastation. After six long years, the war finally came to an end in 1945.

World War II began as a result of the aggressive actions of Germany's ruling Nazi Party, led by Adolf Hitler. In September 1939, Hitler ordered the invasion of Poland. In response, France and Britain declared war against Germany. Italy joined forces with Germany in 1940, by which time Germany was in control of large areas of western and central Europe. Both Germany and Italy wanted to create their own empires in Europe and North Africa.

At first, the USSR made a pact with Hitler not to fight Germany, but it joined the Allied forces when Hitler invaded the USSR in June 1941. This invasion started on a massive scale, but German troops were eventually defeated at Stalingrad in February 1943. A year later, boosted by the arrival of US troops, Allied armies landed in German-occupied France and slowly moved toward Germany, forcing it to surrender in May 1945.



▲ GERMANY ADVANCES

For the first seven months after the outbreak of war no fighting took place in western Europe, a period known as the "Phony war." Then, in April 1940, Germany suddenly attacked Denmark and Norway and in May moved to invade France, Belgium, Luxembourg, and the Netherlands. German troops marched into Paris (above) on June 14, 1940.

EVERYDAY LIFE

When war broke out, governments introduced rationing, a system that limited the amount of food and other items that people could buy. Windows had to be covered at night to prevent light escaping to guide enemy bombers. During bombing raids, people sought protection underground and in specially built shelters. In Britain, children were moved out of the cities to the countryside in case of air attacks (below).



▼ THE BLITZ

In the summer of 1940, Hitler commanded Germany's air force (the Luftwaffe) to attack British planes in the skies in order to prepare for a land invasion. When that failed, he switched to bombing British cities—a campaign called the Blitz (German for "lightning"). For eight months, London and other major cities were ruthlessly bombarded. Up to 43,000 civilians were killed and many more injured before Hitler called off the campaign in 1941.

